STUDENTS' MOVEMENT, 1974

Bihar

A STORM CALLED JP

In 1974, socialist leader Jayaprakash Narayan (JP) launched a movement called Students for Democratic Governance in Bihar, which soon caught the popular imagination at a time when India was getting increasingly restive because of soaring prices, growing unemployment and an indifferent Congress government at the Centre. Launched initially as a students' movement in Bihar, the idea soon spread like wildfire across India. When JP finally addressed a public meeting in Patna on June 5, 1974 and gave the call for '*Sampoorna Kranti* (Total Revolution)', almost 500,000 people attended the rally.

JP attracted people from every section of society, all with the common aim of changing the government, and then society. Though India Gandhi continued with her government and finally clamped Emergency on the country on June 25, 1975, the subsequent expansion of the Total Revolution movement across the country transformed JP into the most powerful anti-government force since Independence. ■

–Amitabh Srivastava



▶ JP at the Gandhi Maidan rally in Patna, 1974

DEMOCRACY'S REVENGE When elections were held in 1977, the Congress party was routed. India, for the first time, had a non-Congress government

Chorus Against Coercion

STUDENTS' MOVEMENT DURING THE EMERGENCY, 1975

Pan-India



▶ A young Arun Jaitley (right), then the Delhi University Student's Union president, leading an anti-Emergency strike

The Emergency, imposed by then prime minister Indira Gandhi on June 25, 1975, saw bans on political rallies, media censorship, incarceration of Opposition leaders and controversial measures, such as coercive sterilisation—all leading to severe curbs on individual and institutional freedoms. At first, Emergency created a false sense of order. The government, for instance, claimed trains were running on time and—with strikes banned—industrial output was picking up. Indira Gandhi announced a 20-point programme to tackle various challenges, such as inflation, making farm production sustainable and streamlining the public distribution system. She brought in legislation to cap rural land ownership.

At the same time, there was rampant misuse of the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA). Outright victimisation, mistaken identities and flimsy suspicions were cause enough for people to end up in detention. The controls and gags became instant anathema for youth across the political spectrum. An undercurrent began to swell as their leaders, except those sympathetic to the Congress, were rounded up and jailed. A spirited movement pushed for the dislodging of the Indira government. She revoked the Emergency in March 1977 and called for general elections, only to be swept out of power by the Janata Party. ■

–Amarnath K. Menon

A LESSON FOR LIFE The Emergency underscored the need to uphold civil liberties and strengthen democratic institutions, and proved that coercive tactics, such as sterilisation, were bound to boomerang on parties and their government